6. Jacques Kallis: Top all-rounder. Outstanding in the field.
7. Adam Gilchrist: Great keeper, great batsman, great tactician.
8. Shahid Afridi: Enough said.
9. Wasim Akram: As explained earlier.
10. Glenn McGrath: Nobody's been more accurate with a new ball. Nobody. Plus, I wouldn't want to face him on any morning of the year.
11. Shane Warne: Can turn around any match, no pun intended.

Let it be noted for the record that Wasim Akram would be skipper.

Now for perhaps the most controversial bit: my all-time best Pakistan–India XI:

1. Saeed Anwar: Again, I love aggressive openers. He looks good when he starts. It's a treat to watch him. Plus, he handles situations well.
2. Virender Sehwag: As aggressive. Will add to a positive start. Will pair up well with Saeed.
3. Virat Kohli: World class. Great game awareness as well as self-awareness.
4. Sachin Tendulkar: The king of any middle order. The king, period.
5. Inzamam-ul-Haq: Can handle the pressure of the middle order. Crucial situational awareness.
6. Imran Khan: Captain of this side. Born leader. Best all-rounder the subcontinent has produced.
7. M.S. Dhoni: Hitter, finisher, keeper, soldier.
8. Wasim Akram: Without a doubt.
9. Shoaib Akhtar: Speed star. The terror of any batting line-up.
10. Waqar Younis: Reverse swing specialist, great partner to Wasim.
11. Anil Kumble: Natural wicket-taker. Mr Line and Length.

Let it also be noted that during my time in Pakistan cricket, I've seen a lot of potential go to waste, untapped. Nadeem Iqbal, a brilliant right-handed Peshawari paceman, could never make it, despite taking 258 wickets in 80 first-class matches with an economy of 3.04. He had 13 five-wicket hauls. Nadeem had a lot of talent but not a lot of luck. So did Javed Qadeer, a solid wicketkeeping batsman. He had a lot of competition, like Rashid Latif, for example, which looped him out of the big leagues. Also, Shadab Kabir, a solid left-handed batsman and my roommate in Nairobi when I debuted, was hugely talented but also had a lot of competition.

None of that matters, though.

You can try, try and try again. But your *taqdeer*, fate, has already been decided.